

ters into fashion studios. "Amer will be a day-long destination, a major tourism splash," says Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje.

Her logic: "World over, heritage has survived only when clubbed with modern tourism." She cites the example of Spain's Paradori—high-class hotels being run in castles and Covent Garden, London, being transformed from a poorly-maintained structure to a popular shopping centre by Liberty International, a group which specialises in retail and real estate. Sensing the business value of such transformation, she signed a memorandum of understanding in May with Liberty to invest in developing some heritage sites, though how it takes shape is yet to be worked out.

"I am pushing forward the concept of living monuments," she says, insisting that the present approach of keeping them devoid of life is as detrimental as keeping a house locked for ages. She cites the example of her Gwalior palace, which is more than 100 years old and is well-maintained because the family lives in it.

The task of restoration has not been easy though with Amer Fort being only half way through its renovation despite it being among the earliest of Raje's projects. Her efforts to rope in eminent people from diverse fields like industrialists, hoteliers, event managers, conservationists from NGOs like INTACH and the Jaipur Virasat Foundation, besides activists, architects and media personalities in the governing council which she initially headed herself, proved futile as these people, apart from lending their names to the project, did little else for it. Plans were then changed and the Chief Secretary asked to head an executive committee of persons who could meet more often, devote time and advise on technical issues as well. Thereafter, through an act of legislation, the Amer Development and Management Authority

PACKAGING THE PAST

- Jaleb Chowk, near City Palace, is being converted into a heritage hub of shops and restaurants.
- The Town Hall, an old assembly building, is being transformed into a museum.
- Sisodiya Rani ka Bagh, a Mughal-Rajput structure, has been renovated. A cafe is going to start here soon.
- Roop Niwas, a rehabilitation centre for destitute women, being restored to its original glory of a garden on the lines of Shalimar.
- Albert Hall, a museum, is being given a modern touch.
- Amer town, adjoining the Fort, is being transformed into a heritage village with walkways and day-long activities.

Society was created to be supervised under a governing council.

Locals though are apprehensive about these efforts as conservation projects in the past have failed to yield the desired results. The recent renovation of a step-well known as Panna Miyan ka Kund in Amer at a cost of Rs 40 lakh, where Prince Charles also paid a visit, has gone down the drain as the place, instead of becoming a picnic spot, continues to be used as a shelter by vagabonds and labourers.

But an unfazed Raje has asked her officers to carry on with the Rs 40-crore conservation plan of the Amer Fort which has brought to light some hidden corridors, a 265 m tunnel, new rooms, halls, water conservation system and step wells. A badly-damaged Sheesh Mahal is being painstakingly repaired with new mirrors and water-proofing.

The efforts make sense too as the Fort earns Rs 4 crore every year but gets only Rs 1 crore for maintenance and upkeep. Post renovation, the Amer Authority will get two-thirds of the revenue it is expected to generate and will be competing with privately-owned forts and palaces although there is no decision on whether to open it for marriage receptions too. Similar plans are afoot for Albert Hall, a 140-year old building which houses a government museum, and Jaleb Chowk, in the walled city near the City Palace.

But Raje's approach has given rise to a new debate—whether the use of such buildings for heritage tourism instead of utilising them for running offices falls under the definition of official use or not. Also, while she is encouraging private participation in these projects in a big way, the Government will have to ensure that heritage monuments do not go beyond the reach of common man. Public should not be made to pay for private profits and major decisions should be taken by the Government's own department.



Raje at Amer Fort